

Research Statement

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1 Vision

My research addresses issues and policies that affect the economics of Labor and Health through both natural and manufactured experiments. Using creative data sources not often used by economists, but used in other fields, I can examine problems that other researchers have struggled to answer. With these data sources and improved methods of modern applied econometrics, I can create research and write papers that can effect future policy changes. I have conducted research pertaining to policy changes relating to Same-Sex Marriage (SSM) and the Affordable Care Act (ACA) using health data and labor data to look at family formation by utilizing rarely used Assisted Reproductive Technology clinic data. I have also created and run an experiment to generate my own data to test the validity of spillover effects of employment protections for individuals that list pronouns on their resumes. These novel methods work towards my goal of making my research central to driving these evidence-based changes in health and labor policies, and I plan to devote my future work to achieving similar results.

2 Dissertation Research

2.1 Fertility and Birth Rate Policies

Same-sex marriage has had substantial impacts on the composition of same-sex households. Due to difficulties in creating data that identifies these individuals and the small size of this community, researchers have struggled to examine fertility methods among this group. I use data from the Centers for Disease Control (CDC), manually linked across years, and data from the American Community Survey (ACS) to answer new questions using causal inference methods, such as staggered timing difference-in-difference models. Two of my papers use these datasets and work in conjunction to fill this gap in the literature.

The first is my job market paper, “Another Baby Boom? How Same-Sex Marriage and the Affordable Care Act Increased Births in the U.S.” I use high-quality CDC data to investigate the expansion of healthcare’s effect on Assisted Reproductive Technology (ART) clinic birth

rates primarily through In-Vitro Fertilization (IVF) procedures using the policies of same-sex marriage (SSM) and the Affordable Care Act (ACA). I find that the ACA caused sustained increases in frozen (cheaper) birth methods in states with insurance coverage mandates relative to states without these mandates. This increase is due to the expansion of that coverage to include Medicaid. Meanwhile, I find evidence that SSM caused increases in frozen births that specifically use donated materials, driven by same-sex individuals increasing their use of ART after the policy change. This effect returns to zero due to an exhaustion of demand and the growth in the number of clinics after these policies. Using this novel analysis, I am the first individual to find that SSM caused increases in births through same-sex individuals using IVF.

This research was influenced by findings from my work on “Same-Sex Marriage Legalization and Adoptive Same-Sex Families.” In this paper, I use ACS data to identify and examine adoptive same-sex families and the effect that SSM has on family formation. Using a control group of opposite-sex households, I observe a decrease in the number of adoptive lesbian households after SSM but no change in adoptive gay households. This is coupled with large increases in household income in the bottom quartile of adoptive lesbian households and no changes in the number of children in same-sex households. Therefore, this is likely due to individuals in the bottom quartile viewing ART as a substitute for child adoption, leading them to leave the sample. This is consistent with other research, as the spouse with the lower salary would be more likely to carry the child to term and/or raise children in the household, while the higher-salaried individual is more likely to keep their job to support the family.

2.2 Randomized Control Trial and Resume Audit Study

I also explore previously unanswered questions regarding discrimination in the hiring process and to assess the efficacy of state-level protections in mitigating this discrimination. Due to the difficulties in collecting data to study individuals in small subgroups, it can often be beneficial to create an experiment to test hypotheses that represents those individuals

which does not endanger them and provides a sufficiently large sample size. It also avoids issues where the individual may not be identifiable as same-sex. One research method to address this is by conducting a resume audit study to test hiring discrimination while changing only one attribute of a resume.

My paper, “State-Level Protections for LGBTQ+ Individuals and Hiring Discrimination Against Non-Binary, Transgender Individuals,” uses the aforementioned resume audit study to attempt to answer three questions. Firstly: What is the magnitude of discrimination against individuals who include pronouns on their resumes? Secondly: Do individuals with non-binary pronouns experience greater discrimination than those with CIS-gendered pronouns? The final and largest contribution is to examine whether state-level employment protections for LGBTQ+ individuals have a spillover effect on the hiring process for individuals who use pronouns, as these may serve as an identifier of a transgender identity. After conducting a power test in New Jersey, I calculated a necessary sample size of 3,200 resumes, sent in pairs of two to 1,600 jobs, with one resume containing pronouns and the other containing none. I began sending out resumes in April 2024, and I expect to have final results fully collected by December, with analysis completed over January 2026.

3 Future Research Directions

I plan to focus my future research primarily on looking into other policies that may affect fertility and health in the US. I also want to focus on using data scraping to form new datasets to examine groups that have been difficult to economically analyze in the past. I believe that, with advances in machine learning and computation, we can more creatively use data and combine datasets than we have in previous research. I plan to leverage my expertise in health, labor, and experimental economics to address questions that have failed to be previously addressed, and to look at small groups of individuals that have yet to be examined in an economic framework using the aforementioned methods.